



Sean Hyunil Sohn  
CEO, Krafton India

# Leveling up

## Decoding India's gaming revolution

Manas Tiwari | [editor@digit.in](mailto:editor@digit.in)

**T**he Indian gaming market, particularly mobile gaming, is experiencing an unprecedented boom. According to a report released at the Game Developers Conference (GDC) by WinZO Games and IEIC, India's online gaming market revenue was \$3.7 billion in 2024.

At the same time, esports is gaining recognition as a viable career path, attracting top talent and massive audiences to tournaments.

At the centre of this transformation is Krafton – the Korean game developer which made one of India's most popular mobile games – Battlegrounds Mobile India or BGMI. In this interview, Sean Hyunil Sohn, CEO of Krafton India spoke about the complexities of one of the fastest-growing gaming markets.

### Cross-cultural perspective

Coming from Korea, a country known for its esports legacy, Sean was struck by India's immense cultural diver-

sity. "The sheer variety of languages, religions, and practices is astounding. It's a stark contrast to Korea's homogeneity," he reflects. This diversity influences gaming preferences, making localisation key to Krafton's strategy.

On a personal note, Sean has embraced India's vibrant lifestyle and culinary delights. Whether it's savoring butter chicken or indulging in South Indian rice dishes like dosa and idli, he believes cultural immersion enriches both life and business. "Traveling across cities and experiencing local flavours has been as rewarding as our work here," he adds.

### India's mobile gaming boom

India's gaming industry is growing at an impressive 15-20% annually, with a current market size of \$3.8 billion. Mobile gaming dominates, thanks to widespread smartphone adoption and affordable internet. However, the country still ranks between 10th and

15th globally, highlighting significant room for growth.

According to Sean, India's massive population and technological advancements offer unparalleled opportunities. The challenge lies in fostering local publishers, diversifying game genres, and navigating cultural perceptions that still view gaming with skepticism.

"Generational gaps and limited awareness hinder mainstream acceptance. It's similar to how television was initially perceived in the US," he notes.

### Krafton's playbook

Krafton's flagship game, Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI), is a testament to the power of localisation. By tailoring content to Indian tastes, the game has achieved widespread success. Regular updates, new maps, and engaging features keep the player base hooked, while tournaments like BGIS and BGMS foster a vibrant esports scene.

"Esports is more than just gaming; it's a social phenomenon," Sean emphasises. These tournaments not only engage players but also create job opportunities and cultural pride, echoing South Korea's esports legacy. Krafton's investment in infrastructure and talent development aims to replicate this success in India.

### Hurdles and opportunities

Investment is another key challenge. Developing AAA-quality games requires \$10-30 million – a significant hurdle for local studios. While India excels in casual and mid-tier games, high-end titles like GTA remain out of reach. "With strategic investments and technological advancements, India could produce world-class games within 5-7 years," Sean predicts. **d**

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